One day, he takes extra time and calls up a few of the downstream consumers of the data product. They tell him they are making a lot out of the Actors part of the data product. To John's dismay, he is not able to find a single customer who's using the Movie Roles dataset. This is really confusing for John because he thought this is one of the most important pieces to accompany the Actors dataset.

So he asks the consumers. The answer is shockingly simple: "Yes, we would really like to use the Movie Roles dataset, but you're providing them in a custom format we're not able to process further."

A frustrated John goes on to iterate on his product, to incorporate a format the consumers can use. That's how product thinking works, right? Except, in a company, it should not. Outside a company, it usually doesn't work that way either. In the outside world, the producing API would get dozens of "bug reports" or "feature requests" if this situation plays out.

The reason is that consumers and producers of products enter into a *mutual relationship*. Company-internal product consumers, especially in the data realm, sometimes forget that. A mutual relationship means the following:

- *The product producer has responsibilities.* The producer must properly care for the product and make decisions in the best interest of the product. The producer is responsible for informing consumers of updates and for telling them of any plans to drop a column, to change the schema, or vary the meaning of the data.
- *The product consumer has responsibilities.* The consumer must tell the producer what's wrong, what's good, and what's missing. The consumer is also responsible for telling the producer how the data is being used, and which transformations must be applied to the data to make it work for a particular use case.

This mutual relationship sometimes gets lost inside the company context even though it is natural outside of it.

KEY POINT Product thinking works both ways. Products are two-way relationships. Outside the company context, this usually works. But inside a company, this two-way relationship often turns into